INTERNATIONAL SYSTEM IN THE POST-COLD WAR ERA

The Cold War was an important episode in the world history but, by early 1990s, it was accepted that 'Cold War' is over. General Colin Powell, former Chairman of Joint Chiefs of Staff commented, "We have seen our implacable enemy of 40 years vaporize before our eyes". But the fact of the matter is that the end of Cold War may have signalled a victory for the US as is evident from President Bush's (Sr.) much known hype that "We have won" but, at the same time, the World witnessed a fundamental shift in the structure and patterns of international relations.

The end of Cold War witnessed the dismantling of the Soviet bloc in Eastern Europe, the collapse of communism in Eastern Europe, the disintegration of the Soviet Union with the simultaneous unification of Germany, all of which redrew the map of Europe.

With the end of the Cold War and the dismemberment of the Soviet Union, the WARSAW pact also met its doom. The alliance and counter-alliances of the Cold War days presently have assumed a peculiar characteristic with the ones formed by the United States still continuing, for example, the NATO and its activities pertaining to the politics of Europe. A reminder in this direction is the NATO bombing of Kosovo. The gearing up of NATO activities during the mini-war between Georgia and Russia in 2008 also suggests the same.

Post-Cold War scenario has come to be characterized by the return of multipolarity where there is a presence of great powers and small powers. Some scholars also uphold the view that the world has become unipolar with the presence of the sole surviving superpower, the United States. On the other hand, there are other scholars who profess multipolarity and project the emergence of a five-way balance of power system rotating around the United States, Europe, Japan, China, and the present Soviet Union.[22]

Military power, though not a salient feature of world politics in the post-Cold War scenario, still continues to be the most reliable technique serving the interest of the big and powerful states. This became evident soon after the end of the Cold War on the wake of Iraq's invasion of Kuwait and action taken by the US led coalition